

The specifications arms race

Cisco predicts some 25 billion devices will be connected to the Internet by 2015. The number already crossed the Earth's population a long time ago! And so in an era when toasters and toilet seats have started tweeting, perhaps it's a good time to introspect and take stock of what technology means to each one of us.

To me, technology is a means to an end and not the end in itself. Let me give you a few examples to qualify my statement. Believe it or not, I continue to stand resolutely outside the iPad's Borg-like reach and don't own one till date. I just don't find any use for it. I'm saying this after keeping the office iPad with me for a whole month and realising that it's been gathering dust over the duration of its sojourn. The reason is I don't play casual games and all my long-form reading still happens on the PC. I read books on my Kindle Paperwhite and for everything else there's my Nexus 5. I don't care much for the iPad's high pixel density display (yes, I refuse to say Retina) because after all, it's just a display. While the content on it might look a little better, it's not going to show me anything new just because it's a better display. Use the right tools for the right job, is my belief. If you move around and want to read on a larger display, and merely consume data on a device with great battery life, sure the iPad makes sense for you – for you – being the operative word.

Peculiarities like this exist with all sorts of technology.

Look at cameras. It's easy to get sucked into the specs-race here as well. You may have all the knowledge in the world about f-numbers, HDR, spot metering and such, but if you can't compose a good shot with your high end DSLR what use is it all? A camera is just a tool we use to capture a photograph, thus the photograph is important, not so much the camera.

Don't get me wrong, there's nothing wrong with owning nice things. If you have the money sure you can go ahead and buy only top-of-the-line products. But I have a problem if a) you're selling your kidney for high end equipment b) you think you're in a different league altogether once you own that high end piece of technology c) if you think your skill – be it photography, gaming, whatever – is going to improve automatically as a result of the boost in specifications and d) if you're going to delude yourself into believing that the product you've bought is better than everyone else's just because it says so on the box.

Think about it. Will money spent on high-end headphones and amplifiers give you a greater understanding of or appreciation for music if you are someone who doesn't really listen to music all that much? Good audio technology is best enjoyed by those who really like listening to, umm, music.

Even when it comes to the beloved PC, there are some oddities which I haven't been able to fully wrap my head around. Overclocking for the sake of overclocking, for example. Sure, if you're using some really cool set-ups, LN2 et al, and going for records, I can understand. But why would you overclock a system that doesn't need to be OC'ed, i.e it's running all the latest games just fine? If you're OC'ing an older CPU today to eke out that very last bit of performance from it for that five frames per second boost, that's an effort I'd applaud. In fact that's something many of us have done at some point or the other. But today, you have OC product lines from motherboard and GPU manufactures – products designed to be overclocked from the word go, not as a contingency – something I don't quite get considering the premiums they demand. I can't believe that all of those hundreds of thousands of people buying these OC products are doing it for the records out of the box.

This month, Digit built what we believe is India's fastest PC. It's okay for Digit to try and build such a monstrous PC, because quite frankly, WE CAN, and we're indeed a little crazy. If you're mortgaging your house just to show-off your ultra fast PC, I'd seriously question your sanity. The first thing I said when our monster PC was built was "let's play something on it and see how different it looks and how much better the performance is," because after all, a good PC is only as good as the games you can play on it, right? As it turns out, there really aren't any games that can truly stress this dream machine of ours. Ah well, at least there's no better future-proofed PC around.

Point is, it's easy to get so caught up in the pursuit of technological superiority, in the pursuit of what technology promises, that we sometimes forget technology is only a means to an end, not the end in itself.



Siddharth Parwatay
Assistant Editor

siddharth.parwatay@thinkdigit.com

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A handwritten signature in black ink, appearing to read 'Siddharth Parwatay'.

Got feedback about this column?
Drop me a line at:
siddharth.parwatay@thinkdigit.com